and fisheries minister Nitesh Rane of the BJP and Naresh Mhaske, Shiv Sena's Thane MP, joined the demand to raze the tomb, as did Udayanraje Bhosale, Shivaji's descendant and a BJP MP. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis backed the idea, too, but with a caveat. "Some things have to be done legally, because it is [a] protected [monument]," he said.

WHAT HAPPENED IN NAGPUR?

The Muslim groups allege that Hindu right-wing activists burnt an effigy of Aurangzeb's tomb that was covered with a holy cloth. In the riots that ensued, mobs went on a rampage, attacking police personnel and civilians and damaging vehicles and public property. It left 33 people, including



TOGETHER WITH NAGPUR PROTESTS AND VIOLENCE, *CHHAAVA*'S RELEASE HAS EXPOSED FISSURES ACROSS MAHARASHTRA'S SOCIO-POLITICAL LANDSCAPE

three deputy commissioners of police, injured. The Nagpur police have lodged six FIRs against 1,200-odd persons at three police stations for the March 17 violence. Fahim Shamim Khan, president of the Minorities Democratic Party, the alleged mastermind, is among those arrested. He had allegedly led a mob to the Ganeshpeth police station, seeking action against VHP and Bajrang Dal workers. "[The riots] appear to be pre-planned by some people. Action will be taken against them," Fadnavis said in the assembly on March 18. "A patriotic Muslim will never support Aurangzeb," added deputy CM Eknath Shinde.

IS THERE MORE TO THIS CONTROVERSY?

The controversy comes at a time when there is a growing Hindutva assertion in Maharashtra, with institutional backing. Aurangabad's name change was accompanied by that of Osmanabad, which is now Dharashiv. Later, Ahmednagar was rechristened Ahilyanagar in what is seen as an attempt to erase markers of the state's Muslim past. Muslim leaders condemn attempts to target them for the doings of medieval-era rulers. Saner voices note that calls for razing the tomb are misplaced and the monument should be seen as a symbol of the valour of the Marathas, who kept Aurangzeb pinned down in the Deccan, eventually heralding Mughal decline. But, they admit that his veneration is bound to touch a raw nerve, given the state's complex social realities. Incidentally, *Chhaava* has also exposed the Maratha-Brahmin fault lines. Maratha groups allege that it was not Sambhaji's brothers-in-law but his Brahmin clerks who betrayed him to the Mughals, leading to his eventual capture and murder.

WHY IS THERE UNEASE IN THE RULING ALLIANCE?

The competition between the BJP and the Shiv Sena to stress their Hindutva credentials has led to growing unease in the third Mahayuti ally: the Ajit Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). A senior NCP leader told INDIA TODAY that such communal violence did not bode well for Maharashtra. "These conflicts may reduce the state's appeal to potential investors, including those looking to set up base in the ambitious international cargo hub and airport project in Nagpur," he noted. A Shiv Sena functionary admitted that calling for the tomb to be razed was "taking things too far" while another Mahayuti leader feels that though Hindu consolidation helped them come to power with an unprecedented 237 of the state's 288 seats, such emotive issues could start proving to be counterproductive in the long run. ■

KASHMIR

A LIQUOR UPROAR

By Kaleem Geelani

The setting: snow-covered Gulmarg. The occasion: The Elle India fashion show featuring creations—capes, pant suits, skiwear as well as bikinis—by Delhi-based designers Shivan & Narresh. As the models walked down the snow-covered ramp, viewers sat on low-slung chairs, some apparently sipping alcohol. But as videos and images of the show on March 7 were released, it roused the collective anger and indignation of Kashmir. What incensed Kashmiris was the fact that such an "outrageous and immodest" event took place in the holy month of Ramzan, disregarding local sensibilities in the Muslim-majority region. Notes of shocked disapproval came from the very top. Chief Minister Omar Abdullah clarified in the assembly, "This was a private party, organised it privately, in a private hotel and distributed their invitation cards privately. No permission was taken from the government, no...government official was involved." The venue of the show was the Nedous Hotel, owned by the relatives of Omar. The organisers have been summoned by a Srinagar court to appear before it.

The uproar rekindled the continuing demand for prohibition of liquor in Jammu and Kashmir and came as a shot in the arm for the People's Democratic Party's (PDP)

The demand for prohibition comes from the belief that unemployment is pushing youth to alcohol and drugs